# LENDER TO THE NATION

**OVER THREE DECADES AGO,** when A. Manimekhalai entered the banking sector as a probationary officer with the erstwhile Vijaya Bank in Chennai, there was no soft preferential treatment awaiting her. She recalls how she was once posted at a rural branch, which demanded that she ride her scooter 120 km daily to work. She was the only woman in that branch, which was far from the city. But the quest to excel in whatever she did made her forget any inconvenience. "In any role that came to me, I wanted to be the best. I wanted to do things right. I wanted to learn," she says. This was her guiding principle throughout her career as she handled multiple functions that included strategic planning, setting organisational goals, compliance and internal control, among other things. She says taking up different roles at Vijaya Bank over the years wasn't much of a challenge, because "you aspire only when you know that you are ready for it. You need to be ten steps ahead of your own self".

Before Union Bank of India, Manimekhalai was executive director at Canara Bank and played a pivotal role in effecting the successful amalgamation of the latter with Syndicate Bank. She says she did not encounter any discrimination as a woman in the course of her career. "I feel that competence and leadership have no gender. The glass ceiling is within you. You break it within you, and you get out of it," she says. "If you are good (for a leadership role), you take it. I am happy that I can inspire others to take up the role." Since taking up the leadership position at Union Bank in June 2022, she has laid out key measures to make the bank profitable across key functions. That, she feels, can come by "creating parallel lines for banking, since traditional banking (alone) is not giving us that kind of boost". In FY23, the bank's net profit rose 61 per cent to Rs 8,433 crore, while gross non-performing assets (%) dropped to 7.5 per cent from over 11 per cent in FY22. The bank raised Rs 5,000 crore through a qualified institutional placement in August, one of the largest in the sector. Thanks to her efforts, Union Bank has now become a bank you can bank on. ■

***–M.G. Arun***

**ACCOMPLISHMENT**

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**A. Manimekhalai, *56***
***MD & CEO, Union Bank of India***

**INNER DEMON**

"The glass ceiling is within you. You break it within you, and you get out of it"

**EMPOWERING WOMEN**

**The Union Bank Nari Shakti loan scheme plans to enrol as many women entrepreneurs as possible. "Women have to stand up on their feet, pay for themselves and look after their families"**